What Should an MVP Specification Contain?

An integrated, traceable description of the MVP—not just a feature list.

An MVP specification brings together the product reasoning and delivery detail needed to build, review and learn from a coherent first product experience. It should make key decisions, assumptions, scope boundaries and unresolved questions visible rather than hiding them in disconnected documents.

What the specification needs to connect

PRODUCT INTENT

The problem, primary user, context, value and intended outcome.

CORE PRODUCT LOGIC

Core Jobs, capabilities, experience and the core user journey.

DELIVERY DETAIL

Information architecture, data considerations, requirements and acceptance criteria.

BOUNDARIES & LEARNING

MVP inclusions and exclusions, assumptions, success measures, technical boundaries and open decisions.

The central idea

The integrated MVP Specification is the consolidated result of the MVPCompanion process—not an extra stage. Its purpose is to make the product coherent enough to evaluate, implement and revise, while preserving the rationale behind important decisions.

Important

A document can be long and still be weak. Completeness means the necessary reasoning and links are present, not that every section contains maximum detail.

A practical specification structure

The exact document structure can vary with product complexity. These areas should be covered to the level needed for a clear, testable MVP.

1 · PROBLEM, USER & VALUE

Problem definition, primary user and context, intended outcomes, value proposition and key evidence or hypotheses.

2 · CORE JOBS & EXPERIENCE

Core Jobs, user journey, experience principles, information architecture and the product capabilities needed for the core journey.

3 · SCOPE & REQUIREMENTS

MVP boundary, inclusions and exclusions, functional and relevant non-functional requirements, acceptance criteria and dependencies.

4 · DATA & TECHNICAL BOUNDARIES

Data needs, important constraints, integrations or technical boundaries, and unresolved implementation decisions that affect scope or feasibility.

5 · LEARNING & TRACEABILITY

Key assumptions, learning questions, success measures, links from problem through requirement to acceptance and metric, plus open decisions and risks.

Keep it integrated

The areas should connect to each other; they are not independent checkboxes.

What makes the specification useful?

The specification should help different people understand what is being built, why it matters, how to check behavior and what remains unresolved.

Quality principles

COHERENT	The core journey can deliver the intended user outcome.
TRACEABLE	Important requirements link back to user outcomes or learning goals.
TESTABLE	Requirements and acceptance criteria describe observable behavior.
HONEST	Evidence, hypotheses, derived implications and open questions are distinguished.
BOUNDED	The MVP boundary and explicit exclusions are understandable.
ACTIONABLE	Dependencies, constraints and unresolved decisions are visible.
LEARNING-ORIENTED	The specification explains what the team needs to learn and how it will assess progress.

Not a promise of certainty

The specification records the best current reasoning. New evidence may require changes.

Quick self-check: is the specification integrated?

Use this review before treating the specification as ready for human sign-off. Unknowns should remain visible and assigned—not guessed away.

Self-check

- [ ] The problem, primary user, context and intended outcome are clear enough to review.
- [ ] Core Jobs and capabilities support a coherent core journey.
- [ ] The MVP boundary explains inclusions, exclusions and their rationale.
- [ ] Requirements are specific enough to review and acceptance criteria are observable.
- [ ] Data needs, technical boundaries and dependencies are addressed at the necessary level.
- [ ] Evidence, hypotheses, derived implications and open questions are distinguished.
- [ ] Traceability connects user problem and outcome to requirements, acceptance and learning measures.
- [ ] Learning goals, risks and unresolved decisions are visible.
- [ ] The document is internally consistent and suitable for human review.

Specification review notes

The most important gap is…

The next fix needed before sign-off is…

The decision owner / next review step is…

Takeaway

The integrated MVP Specification is the result of connected product reasoning—not a feature list assembled at the end.